



Tutankhamun was buried with fabulous treasure. This detail from the pharaoh's throne shows him being anointed by his wife Ankhesenamun.

probably called themselves Ahhiyawa. They had **migrated from the Balkans** or Anatolia about 500 years earlier. Their **lands** were a **patchwork of small kingdoms**, each later dominated by a palace-citadel such as the ones at Mycenae, Tiryns, and Pylos. They spread their influence through trade. After the collapse of the Minoan Empire c. 1450 BCE, the Mycenaeans took over several sites formerly occupied by the Minoans, including Knossos. After c. 1400 BCE, they also took over Minoan trade networks and **established settlements** on Rhodes, Kos, and the Anatolian mainland.

The Mycenaeans

inherited Minoan arts and crafts, adapting the **Linear A script** to write an early form of Greek known as the

Linear B script. They were **great traders**, and ventured out to Sicily and Italy. A ship believed to be of Canaanite origin, wrecked off Uluburun on the coast of Turkey, was found to contain tin from Iran or Afghanistan, copper and pottery from Cyprus, ivory and jewelry from Egypt, and Mycenaean swords.

The **late Bronze Age** was a time of **unrest in Western Asia**. From 1550–1400 BCE, there was a **struggle between various powers** in the region, including



Aegean civilizations

Around 1450 BCE Mycenaean influence spread throughout the Aegean, including to several sites that had been part of the Minoan Empire.

the Hurrians, Hittites, Elamites, Egyptians, and Kassites. In the 1570s BCE, the Kassites had gained control of Babylon. However, by 1450 BCE, the **Hittite New Kingdom** was **growing in influence**, partly due to an alliance with Egypt. Around this time, the Mitanni dominated Syria, but by the 1400s, the Hittites were fighting for control of the region.

In China, the **Shang civilization** (see 1850–1790 BCE) **flourished** around 1500 BCE, with its rulers dominating a large area of central China. However, the Shang had to regularly fend off threats to their kingdom from nomadic tribes to the north.

Shang capitals were surrounded

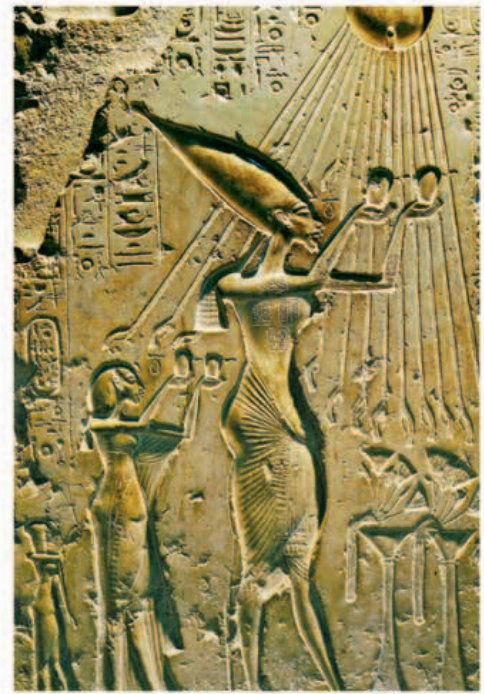
by **defensive walls**. Kings and nobles were buried in tombs, which held fabulous grave goods. The Shang capital moved several times during this period. Shang society was believed to be well organized and extremely hierarchical. Writing began around 1900 BCE. Most examples of **early writing** took the form of **oracle bones**, attesting to the Shang rulers' practice of consulting their ancestors on important decisions. Questions concerning the future were inscribed on the bone of an ox or on a turtle shell, which was then struck with a hot metal tool. The way the bone cracked was believed to provide the answer.

IN c. 1352 BCE, **AMENHOTEP IV**, a religious reformer, became **Egypt's pharaoh**. He broke with the traditional religion, with its pantheon of gods, and **initiated the worship of a single god, Aten**, or sun-disk. He changed his name to Akhenaten, meaning "living spirit of Aten," and founded a **new capital** between Thebes and Memphis. He named it Akhetaten, meaning "horizon of Aten."

Akhenaten's religious reforms were believed to have been unpopular, especially with the influential priestly elite. After his death in c. 1336 BCE, his son **Tutankhamun** ascended the throne at the age of nine. He restored the old gods and abandoned the new capital. Tutankhamun is believed to have died under mysterious circumstances at 18, and was hastily buried in a minor tomb. It was thought for years that Tutankhamun died of a blow to the head, but the latest evidence suggests he died of blood poisoning after breaking his leg in a chariot crash while out hunting in the desert.

Sun worship

Akhenaten instituted the worship of the sun-disk Aten. In this relief carving found at Akhetaten (modern el-Amarna), he is seen worshipping the sun with his wife Nefertiti.



Since the 1570s BCE, Egypt's pharaohs had been buried in rock-cut tombs in the **Valley of the Kings**, on the west bank of the Nile. Rulers hoped their tombs would be safe from robbers, but almost all the **tombs** were **robbed** of their rich goods. However, in 1922, British archaeologist Howard Carter found **Tutankhamun's tomb** virtually intact. The shrine room had four gilded shrines, holding the king's **coffin and mummy** with a solid gold mask. The other rooms contained jewelry, furniture, golden statues, and musical instruments.

c. 1400s BCE Bronze-working spreads to Vietnam and Thailand

c. 1450 BCE Mycenaean trading network stretches from Sicily to the Levant

c. 1400 BCE Shang capital moves from Zhengzhou to Xi'ang in China

c. 1300s BCE Hittite king Suppiluliumas I (r. 1380–1334 BCE) briefly conquers Syria, rivaling Egypt in size

mid-1300s BCE City of Ashur breaks free from Mitannian rule; rise of Assyrian power

c. 1450 BCE Minoan palaces on Crete destroyed; Mycenaeans take control of the island

c. 1336–1327 BCE Brief reign of the boy-king Tutankhamun; old Egyptian religion restored and Akhetaten abandoned

c. 1352–1336 BCE Reign of Amenhotep IV; breaks with Egypt's old religion to worship the sun-disk Aten and takes the name Akhenaten